

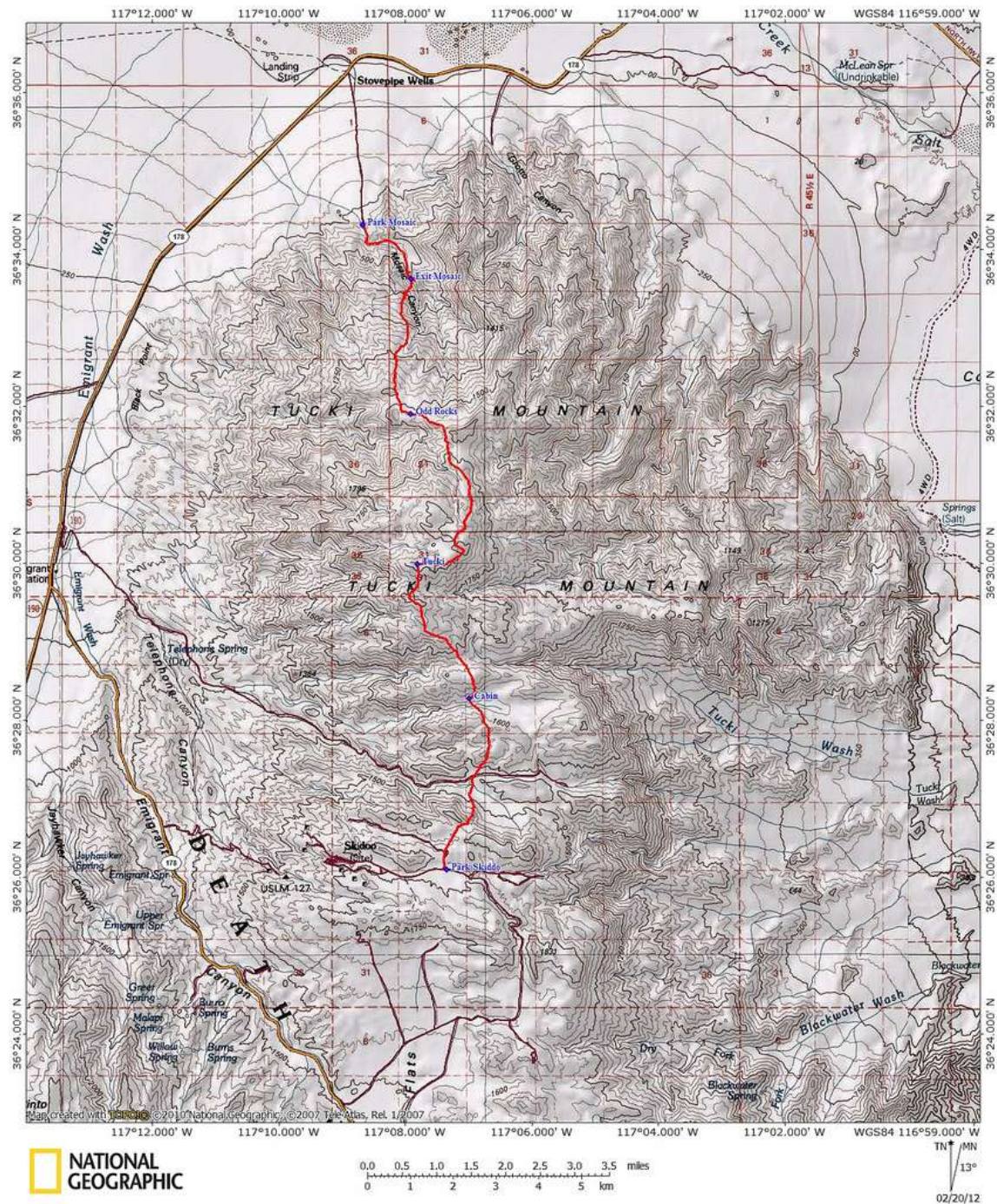
Tucki Mountain Traverse – Mosaic Canyon to Skiddo

February 29th, 2012

14 miles, 8600' gain

Fellow masochistic enthusiasts: Jen Blackie, Anne Kircher, Steve Eckert

Pictures: <http://www.flickr.com/photos/matthewhengst/sets/72157629408961855/>



The weekend of January 21st and 22nd saw Anne and I heading off to Death Valley for two days with the plan of grabbing two DPS peaks Pyramid and Tucki. This would be peak 49 & 50 in the DPS list which contains a total of 99 peaks.



We arrived late Friday night and spent the first few hours Saturday morning getting to the trailhead for Pyramid and seeing a few sights along the way.





Pyramid is an extremely straightforward climb made from a nondescript spot along the 190 southeast of Furnace Creek. Granted it was made a bit more interesting by the strong winds buffeting my Rav4.



They turned out to be hold your sunglasses on to your face strong. Nevertheless we pressed on and by the time we topped out the winds had started to drop off giving us a rather more relaxed of chilly descent.





Once down we even had some daylight left to try and find a campsite that didn't involve a late night rousting or a loud campground full of RVs and generators. We eventually went south to West Side Rd and drove a few miles up the marked-as-a-jeep-road-but-not-really Trail Canyon and settled in for a late dinner.

Sunday was set aside for Tucki. I had found mention online that it was sometimes climbed from Mosaic Canyon in the north instead of the standard route coming from Skidoo in the south. That sounded like a bit more fun whether we managed the peak or not.



Mosaic Canyon is just south of Stovepipe Wells and a very popular hike for tourists. And quite pretty.







This is the end of the accessible section of the canyon. Once we reached this we started to backtrack and explore the canyon on either side trying to find a way up.

After the first few attempts petered out we found a use trail that led us up a rather steep (1000 ft up in .2 miles) canyon wall and appeared to continue towards the peak. Unfortunately by now it was late enough in the day and we were far enough away the math just didn't work for a safe peak attempt considering the terrain we'd just come up.



So reluctantly we backed off and spent the rest of the day exploring a few attractions along the road home.



Like Darwin Falls...



...and the one, the only, Keeler. (I'm pretty sure they rounded up significantly on that population estimate.)

I still wanted to do Tucki from Mosaic and so about a month later we made plans to head back out there. This was still to be my 50th DPS peak (again out of a total of 99) and as an added bonus we'd be hiking in on my 31st birthday. Celebrating in style!

The plan was to leave a car at the southern end of the mountain which is the usual trailhead for climbing Tucki and do a traverse. Steve Eckert volunteered to head for Death Valley a few days early to knock a few other peaks off his wish list and meet us there.

That left Anne, Jen, and myself driving up Saturday night.

I was in LA doing a Sierra Club Advanced Mountaineering Program rock workshop on Saturday and met Anne and Jen at a park and ride near the 405 and 118. Anne had a rather neat surprise for me.





A Vertical Limit themed Irish Car Bomb birthday cake complete with accompanying cupcakes.



(Anyone who doesn't know what Vertical Limit is it's the greatest climbing movie of all time. Go watch this: <http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=uxtg7raPDYo>)

We found Steve's car and tent at a nondescript spot along the road to Skiddo at 10 pm which was apparently the standard Tucki DPS route trailhead. We were all rather happy to see the road to Skiddo was passenger car passable as the Plan B we'd worked out would have involved hiking 10 miles or so down the road to where the pavement started.

We set about tucking in for the night and I quickly found I'd made a slight oversight when I left home that morning. I seemed to have forgotten the two person sleeping bag Anne and I use when car camping.

Oops.

Anne was remarkably accommodating when I told her the good news that we'd be huddling under an emergency blanket in the back of my Rav 4 for the few hours of sleep we were to get.



By morning we were both quite cold. Despite our layers it had dropped down into the 20s overnight and we had layers of ice on all our water containers.

Nevertheless we crawled out of bed at 3:45 am and went about getting ready to shuttle to the other trailhead and hike.

We were the only vehicle at the Mosaic Canyon trailhead when we pulled in and we were hiking by 5:45 am.





We hiked up the canyon about a mile in the dark trying to convince Jen that the canyon she could barely see was actually quite pretty. We had limited success.

The use trail out of the canyon splits off at one point where the Mosaic Canyon trail climbs up the south western wall of the canyon for a brief bit to get around some drops. Instead of returning to the floor of the canyon you take a hard right and head up some steep yet surprisingly stable talus.



This was the best part of the climb as the elevation adds up quickly.



In a surprisingly short time the four of us made the spot where Anne and I had made the call to turn around a few weeks ago. We had a cold wind hitting us but other than that the day was depressingly clear and pleasant.



Sadly we soon hit gentler slopes and the route became less interesting.



Looking back to the north we could see cars starting to wander up the road to Mosaic far below and just barely make out the sand dunes to the right.



We continued south towards point 5205 where we followed the natural ridge around to the east before heading south again towards 6670.



The only real interesting thing we came across was an extrusion of small clear rocks directly to the east of 5205. None of us were sure what exactly they were.



We started to see snow above 6000' but never much of it. We stuck to the ridge which swung around back to the west and the summit though we could have probably saved ourselves a little work just following the canyon between 5670 and 6670.



And then we found our peak.



Umm, wohoo?

2-19-81

Up from Mosaic Canyon

DPS Peak 50'

Matthew Hengst M

↑
(Happy 31st! Woohoo!!)

Anne "Biggles" Kircher M

Jen Blackie

Steve Eckert - Belmont



While the peak itself wasn't quite the most impressive thing I'd ever climbed it did have some nice views. We could see Telescope to the south with a nice bit of snow.



We had left the cars at 5:45 am and with our somewhat relaxed pace made the summit right around 1 pm.

Now we still had to get down and at least three of us had to drive back to Orange County that night.



We followed the ridge down towards 5730 and then descended into a large canyon.



This had something I wanted to see, the Martin Crossing Cabin.



The cabin was another structure similar to those we saw at Panamint City a few weeks back that are maintained by volunteers and free for public use.





Unlike the Panamint cabins this one had obviously suffered a lack of maintenance for a time. There were a large amount of provisions in there but no one had cleaned up the rat droppings in quite a while. Steve's comment was maybe the volunteer had died of Hantavirus...



We poked around a bit and continued on our way as we were getting towards sundown by now. We climbed over the ridge opposite of the cabin though there was an old jeep road heading off to the east. After we descended the southern side we just had the big hump up to the saddle between 5820 and 5950.

It was dark by the time we reached the top and picked our way over to our vehicle though we made it without resorting to headlamps as Steve was happy to point out. Total time had been 5:45 am to 6:30 pm just shy of 13 hours.

We celebrated with cake.





Which can be rather hard to light when there's a slight breeze...



But we persevered...





We drove back around to Mosaic Canyon to get the other vehicle. Steve wasn't planning on driving all the way home that night but the rest of us had to get on the road.

After a long drive I dropped off both Jen and Anne and finally reached home just about at the limit of exhaustion at 2:30 am. Not too bad a way to spend a birthday.